STRAIGHT FROM THE HEART

In *Nikhil Out Loud*, there are glimpses of the struggles author Maulik Pancholy had to face as a gay Indian American



LUKE FONTANA



NIKHIL OUT LOUD
by Maulik Pancholy
HARPERCOLLINS
₹455 (Kindle);
314 pages

Maulik Pancholy is no stranger to the spotlight. He has acted in Broadway plays and played Jonathan on the popular show *30 Rock* (2006-2013). What made him nervous, however, was visiting a middle school in Ohio during a 2019 book tour for his debut novel, *The Best at It*.

"There were, like, 700 kids in the audience and I told them the book is about a 12-year-old Indian American boy who realises that he might be gay," he recounts. "I was nervous because I hadn't been to a middle school in so long... But they started clapping, which was remarkable." They exchanged stories about their struggles. "As part of my presentation, I showed them a picture of me and my husband."

Later, he learnt that a few parents were angry that an openly gay author had come to speak to their kids. "They tried to shut down school assemblies...The kids messaged me on social media, asking how do we make this better. So, I kept thinking, where are the voices of the kids in this? And who is listening to them? That's where *Nikhil Out Loud* (2022) came from." In the book, Nikhil, 13, is 'comfortably out' to his mother, but has to navigate new relationships when they shift from Los Angeles to Ohio.

The stories are fictional, but the experiences are not. "*The Best at It* is so semi-autobiographical—the things that I struggled with in middle school, figuring out who I was, not sure if it was okay to be myself."

During his childhood, Pancholy's family—his parents emigrated from Gujarat—visited India often. "When I was a kid, I never saw Indian characters on TV, billboards or in magazines. And in India, I saw billboards with Bollywood stars. Not that I looked like one," he laughs, "but I could see myself."

Pancholy developed an interest in acting early on. But when he first started auditioning in the late 1990s, he had to tackle offensive questions. "Like, do you have a turban? Can you do an accent?" he says, adding that roles were often for a specific type of Indian American who was the butt of all jokes. But things started changing in the early 2000s, around the time he left Yale School of Drama. "I was more confident pushing for change, too." Soon, he bagged a role in *30 Rock*. "It was like being in a masterclass in screen work and comedy work with Tina [Fey] and Alec [Baldwin]."

When **MAULIK PANCHOLY** first started auditioning for roles in LA, he had to tackle many offensive questions

Through his work on the President's Advisory Commission on Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders under Barack Obama, Pancholy understood the power of storytelling for kids and how important it's for them to see their story in the media. "I realised that that story of being Indian American, being gay, that intersectionality, didn't really exist." He adds that he hopes to write more books. ■

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